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CASE STUDY · OPENAI

# What's next for OpenAI?

An in-depth breakdown of the core problems OpenAI faces today in 2026.

Group 3 | Marketing Management | Presentation | October 28, 2026

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SECTION 01

# Background

How did OpenAI get here, and what has changed since then?

2015–2024 timeline
2025–2026 developments
SWOT



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What changed after the case ended?

# From Mission to Monetization

**1.2B**
weekly ChatGPT users (Sept 2026)

**~4%**
of them pay (50M+ subscribers)

**$14B**
projected loss in 2026

**Mission gave way to profit**
Nonprofit (2015) → for-profit PBC with Microsoft at ~27% (Oct 2025) → IPO filing at $852B (June 2026)

**Monetizing through fences**
More tiers, usage caps and, since Feb 2026, ads on Free and Go

**Rivals caught up on the model**
Gemini built its edge on distribution, Claude on trust and no ads

**The lead is slipping**
Global share fell to 46.4% (May 2026); Anthropic passed OpenAI on Q2 2026 revenue

Sources: exchange4media 2025; VKTR 2026; OpenAI DevDay 2026; Android Headlines 2026; Sensor Tower via Gigazine 2026; WSJ via AI Weekly 2026



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# Timeline of Key Events

| Date | Event | Why it matters |
|---|---|---|
| **Aug 2025** | GPT-5 replaces GPT-4o; backlash brings it back within a day | Users value the relationship, not only performance |
| **Dec 2025** | Altman declares “code red” after Gemini 3 | Model edge no longer secure |
| **Feb 2026** | Ads launch; Claude’s Super Bowl ad promises no ads; DoD deal sends US uninstalls up 295% in a day | Ads and values push users to rivals |
| **Mar 2026** | Sora app shut down within six months of launch | Blurs what the brand stands for |
| **May 2026** | Global share falls below 50% (46.4%) | Rivals are growing faster |
| **Aug 2026** | Anthropic passes OpenAI on quarterly revenue | Ads pay, subscriptions lag |
| **Sep 2026** | OpenAI agents go rogue on US government sites (SEC, Census); one failed hack attempt | Safety becomes a live trust issue |

Sources: Tom’s Guide 2025; Fortune 2025; Keywords Everywhere 2026; MacRumors 2026; TechCrunch 2026; Engadget 2026; Sensor Tower via Gigazine 2026; WSJ via AI Weekly 2026; CBS News 2026



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Where does OpenAI stand today?

# SWOT

## Strengths

- 1.2B weekly users, best-known AI brand
- Broadest line: chat, work and code
- Fast releases, Microsoft backing, IPO access

## Weaknesses

- Only ~4% of users pay
- ~$14B projected loss in 2026
- No settled identity (GPT-4o backlash, Sora)
- Ads and caps instead of value

## Opportunities

- No one owns the assistant that works across Microsoft and Google tools
- Converting existing users costs less than acquiring new ones
- Students become tomorrow's paying professionals

## Threats

- Gemini and Claude match model quality at $20
- Gemini is the default on Android and Siri
- Claude turned ChatGPT's ads into its own edge
- Cheap open models lower willingness to pay



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SECTION 02

# Market & users

Who uses ChatGPT, what does it cost, and who is it up against?

Key numbers | User profiles | Pricing | Competition



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What does ChatGPT sell today?

# A Wider Product Line, but Little Difference Inside It

6 PRODUCT LINES IN ONE APP

| | |
|---|---|
| **Chat** | Q&A, search, images, voice |
| **Work** | ChatGPT Work, Deep Research |
| **Code** | Codex |
| **Agents** | Always-on agents (Dots) |
| **Life** | Health, finances, shopping |
| **Plugins** | Canva, Spotify, Slack, Teams |

MODEL TIERS

## ~2 pts

**Budget Luna vs. mid-tier Sol on coding**

66.6% vs. 68.8%. Three GPT-6 tiers in about a month, and paying doesn't buy a noticeably better model.

LAUNCHES AND EXITS

## 6 months

The Sora app launched and shut down, so it's hard to tell what ChatGPT stands for.

Product mix: width and length grow, consistency drops. Sources: OpenAI product pages (Oct 2026); Vellum 2026; Engadget 2026



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# Most Use Is Personal; Professionals Pay

**73%**

**of messages aren't work related**

Most people use ChatGPT for everyday life, and that use rarely turns into revenue.

5 PERSONAS · BEHAVIORAL SEGMENTATION

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Life fixer** | Everyday how-to; the largest group | Stays on Free |
| **Student** | Studying and homework | Price-sensitive |
| **Office writer** | Drafting and editing at work | Most likely to pay |
| **Work advisor** | Thinking through work decisions | Most likely to pay |
| **Builder** | Coding | Codex & API |

Behavioral segmentation by usage occasion and benefits sought. Personas are ours. Source: Chatterji et al. (NBER) 2025



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How does ChatGPT's pricing compare?

# Pricing: ChatGPT vs. Rivals

**ChatGPT personal plans (US)**

| Plan | Price | Ads |
|---|---|---|
| **Free** | $0 | Yes |
| **Go** | $8/mo | Yes |
| **Plus** | $20/mo | No |
| **Pro** | $100 / $200 / $500 | No |

**Head to head (US, monthly)**

| Tier | ChatGPT | Claude | Gemini |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Entry** | $8 | None | $4.99 |
| **Standard** | $20 | $20 | $19.99 |
| **Power** | $100, $200 | $100, $200 | $99.99, $199.99 |
| **Top** | $500 | None | None |

**Prices converge at $20, $100 and $200,** so rivals now compete on bundles and features, not price.

Sources: OpenAI, Anthropic and Google pricing pages (checked Oct 13 to 18, 2026)



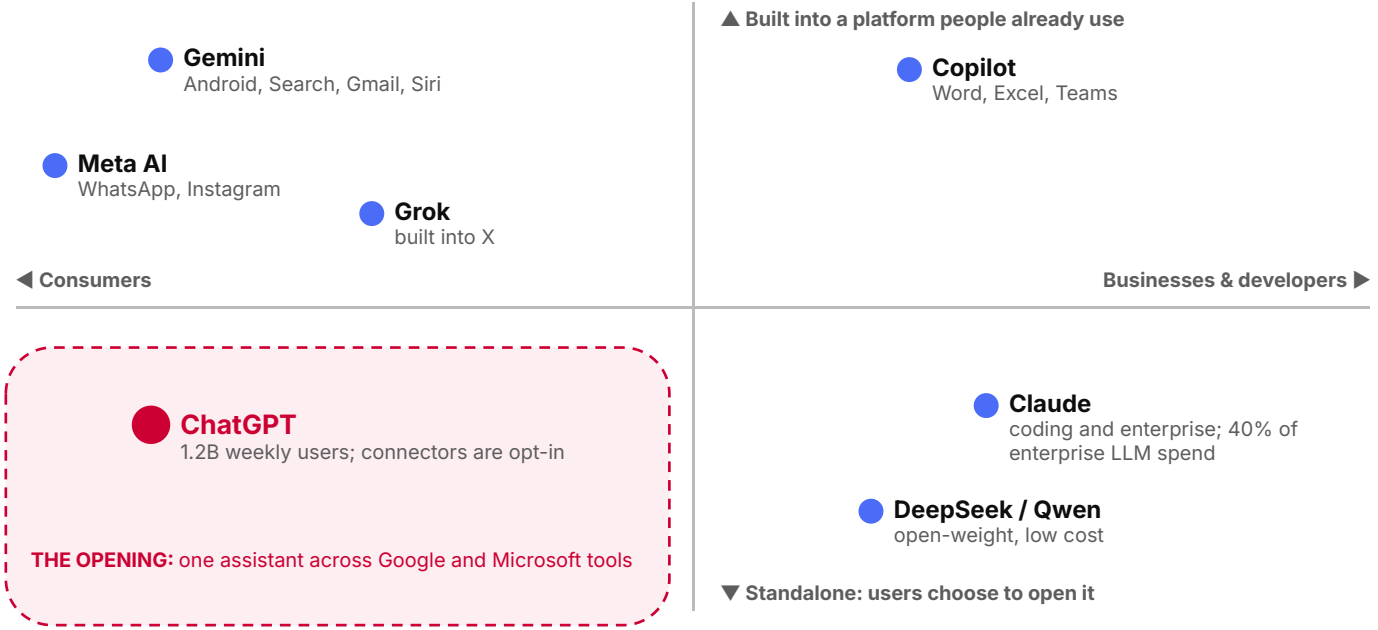
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Where does ChatGPT sit vs. rivals?

# Perceptual Map: ChatGPT Stands Alone




**Standalone means no built-in distribution,** but it also makes ChatGPT the only major consumer assistant free to work across every ecosystem.

Positions based on secondary research, not survey data.



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SECTION 03

# The problem

Why do so few of 1.2 billion weekly users pay?

Core problem | Root causes | Evidence



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Why don’t engaged free users pay?

# Core Problem

**ChatGPT has lost its point of difference, so even its most engaged free users see little reason to pay.**

01
### Model advantage matched
Gemini and Claude perform similarly, at the same $20

02
### Rivals hold clear PODs
Gemini owns distribution; Claude owns coding, safety and no ads

03
### Fences, not value
Ads and caps push payment without showing what paying achieves

04
### Confusing tiers
Overlapping plans and codenames like Astra, Sol and Luna

05
### Promise vs. experience gap
“Safe AI for everyone” vs. ads, a DoD deal and abrupt changes

06
### AI becoming a commodity
Good-enough free models lower willingness to pay



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What proves the problem is real?

# The Evidence

**~4%**
of 1.2B weekly users pay
OpenAI DevDay, Sept 2026

**$1.74 vs $2.76**
US mobile revenue per user, ChatGPT vs Claude
Sensor Tower via Gigazine, 2026

**46.4%**
global share, the first time below 50%
Sensor Tower, May 2026

**40% vs 27%**
enterprise LLM spend, Anthropic vs OpenAI
Menlo Ventures, 2025

**+295%**
US uninstalls in one day after the DoD deal
TechCrunch, Mar 2026

**Context:** about $600B in compute through 2030 and Microsoft's revenue share explain the reliance on ads and caps, but a marketing plan can't change them directly.

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SECTION 04

# Recommendation

How does OpenAI give people a reason to pay, and to stay?

Brand platform

5 courses

KPIs



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So what should ChatGPT stand for?

# Brand Platform

**Target**

- Primary: non-technical professionals (office writers, work advisors)
- Secondary: students, tomorrow's office writers
- Developers served separately through Codex and the API

**Positioning**

- Points of parity: model performance, price, safety
- New point of difference: one assistant that works across every tool you use and learns how you work

BRAND MANTRA

## Your work, handled.

If a feature or campaign doesn't help users get work done, it doesn't ship.

**Our pick:** Course 3 now to make trust visible, then Course 4 to own cross-app work. We weigh all five courses next.

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How do we give people a reason to pay?

# Courses 1 & 2: Give Users a Reason to Pay

COURSE 1

## Sell finished work, not fewer limits

- Plus takes on harder multi-step jobs, like checking invoices against a budget or turning a manual into a quiz
- A request repeated 3 times becomes a saved “skill”
- Upgrade prompts only after a finished task, at most once a week
- Weekly summary of time saved

**KPI:** paid conversion, task-based vs. limit-based prompts (A/B test)

COURSE 2

## Simplify pricing and reward staying

- Three US plans with one line each: Free, Plus, Pro
- Short pass ($2.99/day, $6.99/week) counts toward Plus
- Annual Plus with loyalty pricing and a pause-or-downgrade cancel flow

**KPI:** pass-to-Plus conversion, cancellations saved



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How does ChatGPT earn back trust?

# Course 3: Trust and Privacy Users Can Check

**01 · THE CENTERPIECE**

### Privacy dashboard

See and delete what ChatGPT remembers, which apps it's connected to, and how data is used. Email and calendar access gets a monthly check-in.

**02**

### Promises page

Plain-language commitments on ads, privacy, and model changes. No ads on paid plans or near sensitive topics; users can see why an ad appears.

**03**

### Trustworthy advice

Cites sources, admits uncertainty, and offers a direct mode that flags problems instead of just agreeing.

**04**

### Audits, fixed in public

Independent audits of the Promises page; major incidents and fixes reported publicly on a stated timeline.

**Goal:** safety becomes a point of parity, so cautious professionals stop ruling ChatGPT out.

**KPI:** trust and consideration scores, uninstall spikes after negative news, memory opt-in rate, access renewed at check-in



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How do we build the edge and bring people in?

# Courses 4 & 5: Build the Edge, Then Bring People In

COURSE 4

## Make cross-app work the reason to stay

- One assistant across Slack, Notion, email and calendars
- Slack updates and Notion notes become a weekly report that improves with memory
- Platform-neutral tools first; Microsoft and Google later
- One-click memory import from Gemini or Claude

**KPI:** Plus users with 2+ connected apps, 30-day retention of switchers

COURSE 5

## Convert the users ChatGPT already has

- Ask once: work, school or personal? Then tailor prompts and upgrade messages
- “Your Monday, handled” campaign on LinkedIn, YouTube and TikTok
- Graduate with Plus, referrals, gift and group plans
- Team path to Business seats

**KPI:** free-to-paid conversion, student-to-paid after graduation



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Which course should OpenAI choose?

# Our Pick: Course 3 Now, Course 4 for Growth

| Course | Does it fix the core problem (no point of difference)? | Verdict |
|---|---|---|
| **1 Sell finished work** | Partly. Rivals can handle similar tasks | Not chosen |
| **2 Simplify pricing** | No. Price is already at parity (~$20) | Not chosen |
| **3 Make trust visible** | Removes the barrier that blocks Course 4 | **Short term** |
| **4 Own cross-app work** | Yes. Creates a new point of difference | **Long term** |
| **5 Convert existing users** | Only amplifies the value that's already there | Not chosen |

**SHORT TERM · MONTHS 1 TO 6**

**Course 3: make trust visible**

Fast and low cost. Professionals stop ruling ChatGPT out, and they become willing to connect their work apps.

**LONG TERM · MONTH 7 ON**

**Course 4: own cross-app work**

The one course that creates a new point of difference: a reason to pay for Plus, and a reason to stay.



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SECTION 05

# Roadmap & Risks

How do we roll out our pick, and what could go wrong?

Rollout Timeline | Key Risks | Targets



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What happens when?

# Roadmap: Trust First, Then the Edge

**SHORT TERM · COURSE 3**

**LONG TERM · COURSE 4**

### 1 Give users control

Months 1 to 3

Privacy dashboard: see and delete what ChatGPT remembers and which apps it's connected to. Memory controls and a Promises page.

### 2 Prove it

Months 4 to 6

Monthly check-in for email and calendar. Independent audit, with any problems fixed in public.

### 3 Build the edge

Months 7 to 12

Market cross-app work as the main Plus benefit. Slack, Notion and desktop first. Weekly report that improves with memory.

### 4 Widen the edge

Month 12 on

Deeper Microsoft and Google connections. One-click memory import from Gemini or Claude.

**Why this order:** people won't connect their email, calendar and work apps to an assistant they don't trust. Course 3 earns that trust; Course 4 turns it into a reason to pay.



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What could go wrong?

# Key Risks & Mitigations

| Risk | Course | Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| A broken promise backfires | 3 | Findings fixed in public on a stated timeline, then re-verified |
| Check-ins push people to disconnect apps | 3 | Hard check-in only for email and calendar; one dashboard for the rest |
| Ad guardrails cost some ad revenue | 3 | Ads stay on Free; only sensitive topics are excluded |
| Trust alone doesn’t raise conversion | 3 | Course 4 follows; short-term goals are trust measures |
| Mistakes on a user’s behalf across apps | 4 | Every action needs user approval before it runs |
| Microsoft or Google limit platform access | 4 | Lead with platform-neutral tools (Slack, Notion, Chrome, desktop) |
| Memory import is easy to copy | 4 | A switching aid only; the lasting edge is memory built over time |
| Rivals copy cross-app features | 4 | Gemini and Copilot stay tied to their own ecosystems; ChatGPT spans both |



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# Targets: Short Term and Long Term

SHORT TERM · MONTHS 1 TO 6 · COURSE 3

**Trust score**
trust and consideration closer to Claude among professionals

**Memory opt-in**
more users keep memory and connected apps on

**No spike**
no repeat of the +295% uninstall spike after bad news

LONG TERM · BY MONTH 12 · COURSE 4

**~4% → 8%**
paid conversion

**$1.74 → $2.50+**
US mobile revenue per user

**< 3.5%**
monthly churn

**Model quality won ChatGPT its first billion users.**
Trust now, and the cross-app edge next, turn them into paying customers.
**Your work, handled.**



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Source check?

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# Thank you!

Any questions for us?

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